

RedBox from starting a company and adding “convenience” to the need equation. It was an open road when the road seemed closed.

Beer has been brewed for thousands of years, but that didn’t stop Jim Koch from starting Sam Adams or Sam Calagione from starting Dogfish Head Craft Brewery, now the fastest growing brewery in America. Dogfish was started back in 1995 with a 10-gallon home brew kit and little cash. There was an open road when the road seemed closed.

Garbage has been around since men have walked the planet. Yet that didn’t stop Brian Scudamore from starting and then franchising 1-800-GOT-JUNK, nor did it stop Wayne Huizinga from founding Waste Management with just one truck and a handful of customers. He later built Waste Management into a *Fortune 500* company. Is garbage a new need? Or a need that needed better fulfillment? It was an open road when the road seemed closed.

A blanket with arms? It’s been around for years, but that didn’t stop Snuggie from selling 40 million blankets via infomercial marketing. An old idea better marketed and better executed. It was an open road when the road seemed closed.

MySpace was thriving well before Facebook, but that didn’t stop Mark Zuckerberg. He saw a niche need and solved it. It was an open road when the road seemed closed.

Poorly met needs are open roads when they often appear closed. Successful businesses take existing ideas, services, and products and simply make them better, or spin them in new directions.

HOW TO SPOT OPEN ROADS

Not a day goes by when I don’t spot a need that can be exploited for Fastlane opportunity. My mind is tuned because I see the terrain of opportunity through accustomed senses. I see and hear what most people don’t. How can you tune your eyes and ears to the same attuned frequency? With a little practice, it’s easy.

Open roads, needs and opportunity come prefaced with “code words” or phrases that scream “This is an opportunity!” When you catch yourself (or someone else) in these words, you’ve just uncovered a possible opportunity. Here are the most common phrases:

“I hate . . .”

What do you hate? Solve the hate, and there’s your open road.

“I don’t like . . .”

What don’t you like? Remove the dislike, and there’s your open road.

“This frustrates me . . .”

What is frustrating? Remove the frustration, and there’s your open road.